

Generalized Linear Models

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This section is primarily adapted starting from the textbook “An Introduction to Generalized Linear Models” (4th edition, 2018) by Annette J. Dobson and Adrian G. Barnett:

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The type of predictive model one uses depends on several issues; one is the type of response.

- Measured values such as quantity of a protein, age, weight usually can be handled in an ordinary linear regression model, possibly after a log transformation.
- Patient survival, which may be censored, calls for a different method (survival analysis, Cox regression).
- If the response is binary, then can we use logistic regression models
- If the response is a count, we can use Poisson regression
- If the count has a higher variance than is consistent with the Poisson, we can use a negative binomial or over-dispersed Poisson
- Other forms of response can generate other types of generalized linear models

We need a linear predictor of the same form as in linear regression βx . In theory, such a linear predictor can generate any type of number as a prediction, positive, negative, or zero

We choose a suitable distribution for the type of data we are predicting (normal for any number, gamma for positive numbers, binomial for binary responses, Poisson for counts)

We create a link function which maps the mean of the distribution onto the set of all possible linear prediction results, which is the whole real line $(-\infty, \infty)$. The inverse of the link function takes the linear predictor to the actual prediction.

- Ordinary linear regression has identity link (no transformation by the link function) and uses the normal distribution
- If one is predicting an inherently positive quantity, one may want to use the log link since ex is always positive.
- An alternative to using a generalized linear model with a log link, is to transform the data using the log. This is a device that works well with measurement data and may be usable in other cases, but it cannot be used for 0/1 data or for count data that may be 0.

Table 1: R glm() Families

Family	Links
gaussian	identity , log, inverse
binomial	logit , probit, cauchit, log, cloglog
gamma	inverse , identity, log
inverse.gaussian	1/μ^2 , inverse, identity, log
Poisson	log , identity, sqrt

Family	Links
quasi	identity , logit, probit, cloglog, inverse, log, $1/\mu^2$ and sqrt
quasibinomial	logit , probit, identity, cloglog, inverse, log, $1/\mu^2$ and sqrt
quasipoisson	log , identity, logit, probit, cloglog, inverse, $1/\mu^2$ and sqrt

Table 2: R `glm()` Link Functions; $\eta = X\beta = g(\mu)$

Name	Domain	Range	Link Function	Inverse Link Function
identity	$(-\infty, \infty)$	$(-\infty, \infty)$	$\eta = \mu$	$\mu = \eta$
log	$(0, \infty)$	$(-\infty, \infty)$	$\eta = \log \mu$	$\mu = \exp\{\eta\}$
inverse	$(0, \infty)$	$(0, \infty)$	$\eta = 1/\mu$	$\mu = 1/\eta$
logit	$(0, 1)$	$(-\infty, \infty)$	$\eta = \log \mu / (1 - \mu)$	$\mu = \exp\{\eta\} / (1 + \exp\{\eta\})$
probit	$(0, 1)$	$(-\infty, \infty)$	$\eta = \Phi^{-1}(\mu)$	$\mu = \Phi(\eta)$
cloglog	$(0, 1)$	$(-\infty, \infty)$	$\eta = \log -\log 1 - \mu$	$\mu = 1 - \exp\{-\exp\{\eta\}\}$
$1/\mu^2$	$(0, \infty)$	$(0, \infty)$	$\eta = 1/\mu^2$	$\mu = 1/\sqrt{\eta}$
sqrt	$(0, \infty)$	$(0, \infty)$	$\eta = \sqrt{\mu}$	$\mu = \eta^2$